greeting, the message is much the same as elsewhere. Transcribing the address by the dispatcher to the recipient was obviously a mistake made when the edicts were finally engraved from the common exemplar sent to all three places. However, thanks to this ancient error, we have a rare glimpse into the mode of transmission of the message: we know that the emperor sent it to the provincial governor who, in turn, forwarded it for transcription at different locations within the province he governed.[13]

The provincial functionaries and engravers who were most materially responsible for transmitting Ashoka's messages are shadowy figures. One exception is a character who signed off those three texts in Karnataka. Presumably, he was the 'lipikara' or writer-clerk who prepared the exemplar from which the rock engravings were made. The scribe's name was Capada, this being mentioned in all three edicts—which of course does not necessarily mean he was the engraver.[14] The engraver was more likely to have been a literate worksmith; even more likely, several worksmiths, for though the three texts were inscribed within a few kilometres of each other, the engraving hands are different, indicating more than one engraver.[15] Instead of Brahmi—the script used in the main part of the edict—Capada chose to use Kharoshthi for his own signature. Kharoshthi was frequently used in the area of Gandhara, around the upper Indus and Swat valleys in contemporary north Pakistan, bordering Afghanistan. Capada may have used Kharoshthi for signing off to show his dexterity with scripts, as also perhaps to signal that he either hailed from or was in some way linked with north-west India. The local engraver inscribed his signature along with the emperor's message and so immortalized his name. Of the many writer-clerks likely to have been employed in the administration, he remains the only one we know by name.

While other clerks and engravers are not visible in the same way, sometimes the style of engraving attracts our attention to the particularity of their skill. One such scribe was the engraver of the Erragudi edict in